

The family heirloom had a history that was dubious at best. An uncle's great uncle perhaps, or a mother's grandmother's cousin. Or some such. The item at hand, a large, flawless chandelier, a Waterford original, was said to have been crafted by Penrose himself. It had lived in all kinds of places, having adorned high-ceilinged ballrooms and been crated across all the seas.

Mathew had come to resent its terrible weight in his life. Its inevitable role as a conversation starter had led to the most disastrous marriage, and become the centre stage of its downfall. The relationship had ended in a sea of details and the chandelier bubble-wrapped in the back of a small car weaving toward a studio apartment in the bustle of an overgrown city.

To the present moment. After lugging the thing up six flights of narrow stairs the most lovely thought occurred to him. On an ecstatic whim, and in a bid for ancestral freedom, he hurled it off the top landing. It seemed suspended in mid-air just for the briefest moment before shattering into endless pieces on the marble floor below.

It was a short-lived ecstasy. The kid who lived across the hall had filmed the whole thing, One of those long-haired giant-sneaker types, his face and phone frozen in entertainment. The kid rushed down the stairs and the chase began. Mathew could feel the weight of his ancestors bearing down, demanding he get hold of that footage. He could think of nothing but saving the family name. They tore out of the building into the street and there was a fabulous drama of rain and traffic and Mathew had never felt so alive.